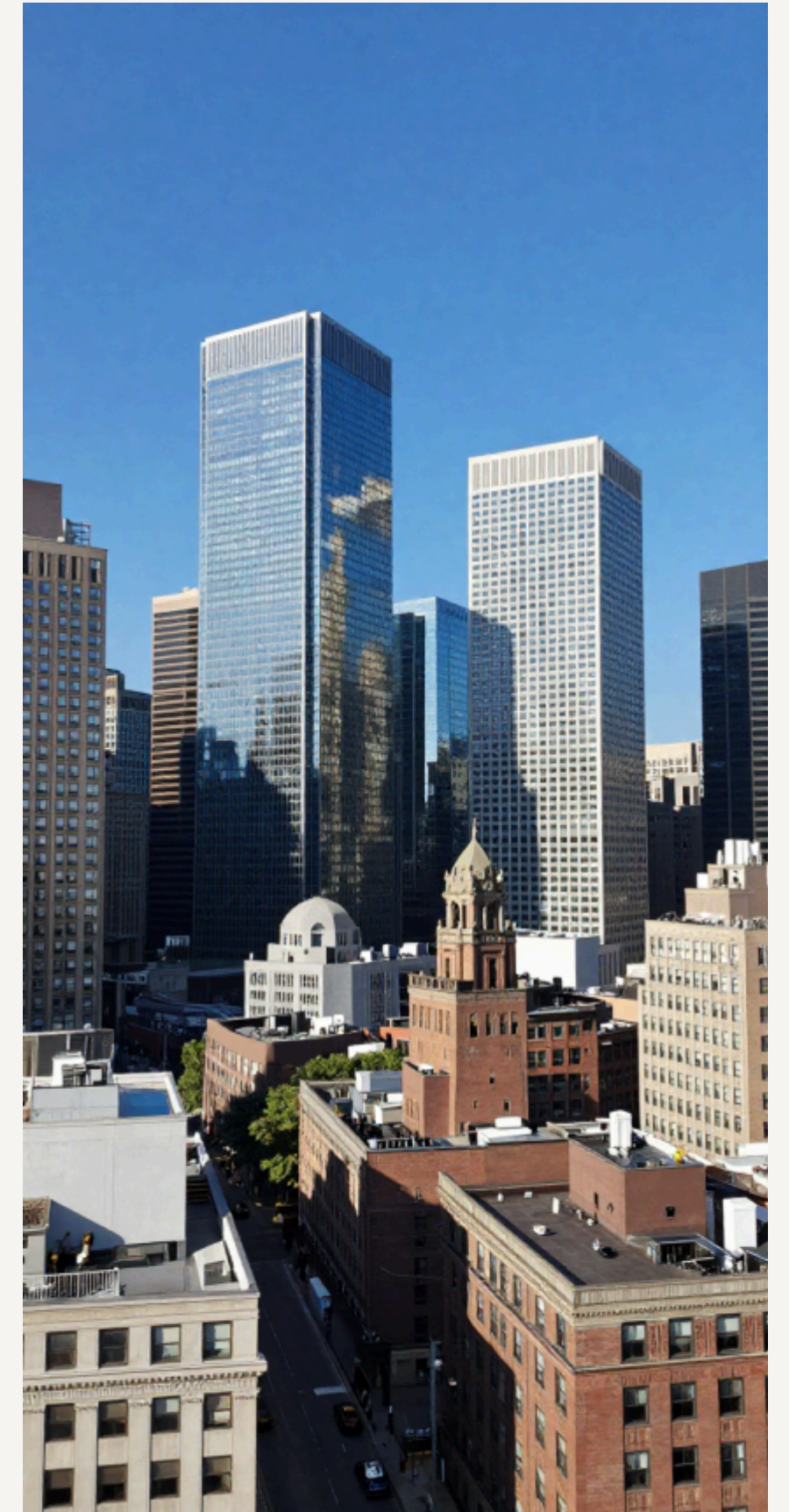

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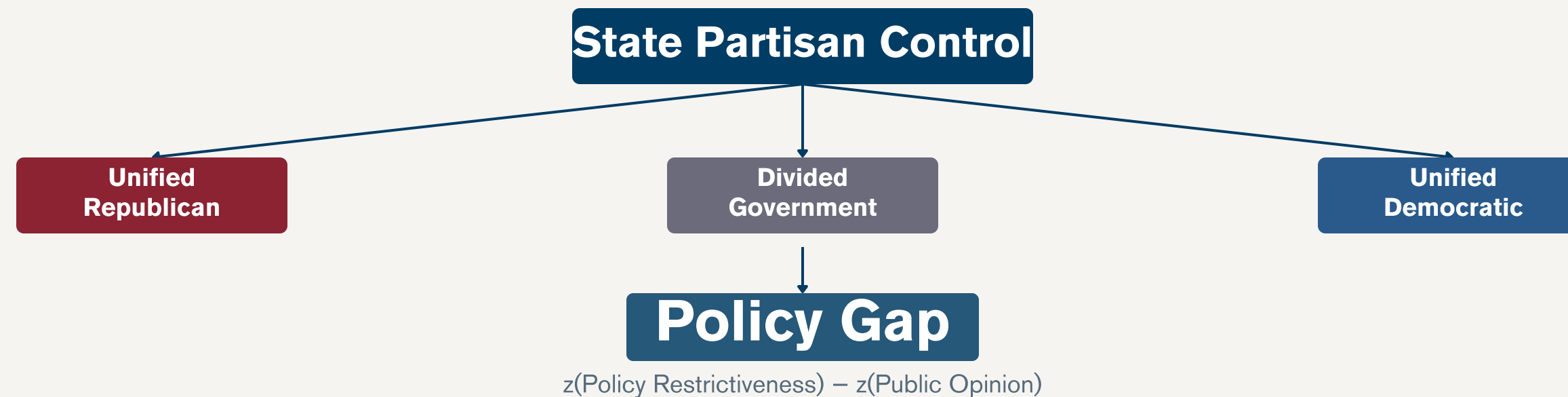
AMERICAN POLITICAL SCIENCE ASSOCIATION

Policy Congruence and Public Opinion on Abortion in the United States (2000-2024)

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How is state government partisan control associated with the direction and magnitude of the policy gap between abortion policy and public opinion across U.S. states from 2000 to 2024?



H1 Unified Republican



Expected Gap: Positive (+)

Compared to divided government, unified Republican will move in the positive direction - more restrictive than public opinion

H2 Unified Democratic



Expected Gap: Negative (-)

Compared to divided government, unified Democratic will move in the negative direction - more permissive than public opinion

H3 Divided Government

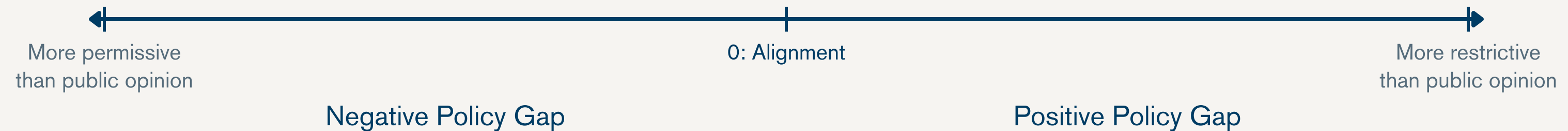


Expected Gap: Near Zero (≈ 0)

Policy roughly aligns with public opinion.

What is the Policy Gap?

$$\text{Policy Gap} = z(\text{Policy Restrictiveness}) - z(\text{Public Opinion})$$



State A	State B	State C
Policy more permissive than opinion	Policy $\approx$ opinion	Policy more restrictive than opinion
Gap = -1.0	Gap = 0	Gap = $+1.0$

Study Design

Unit of Analysis

State-survey-year

Analysis

OLS regression

Study Period

2000-2024

Standard Errors

Clustered by state

Analytic Sample

N = 445 state-survey-year obs.

Reference Category

Divided government

Data Sources

1

General Social Survey (GSS)

Restricted-use state identifiers; Rossi Scale; political ideology; religious attendance

2

Ruger & Sorens State Policy Database

10-item abortion Policy Restrictiveness Index, 2000-2022; extended through 2023-2024 via hand-coded Guttmacher data

3

American Community Survey / Census

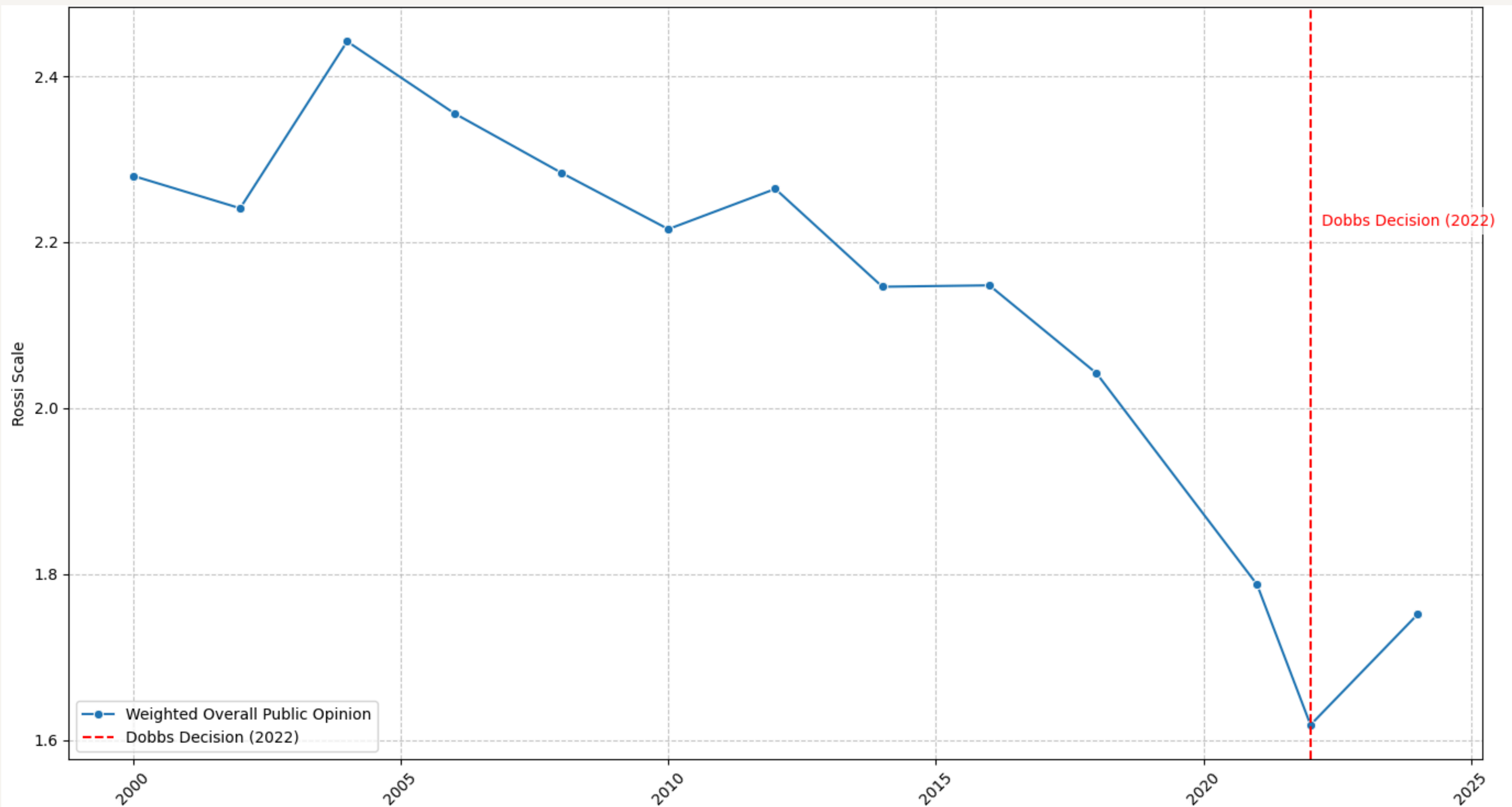
State demographics: education, median age, race/ethnicity, sex, and marital status

4

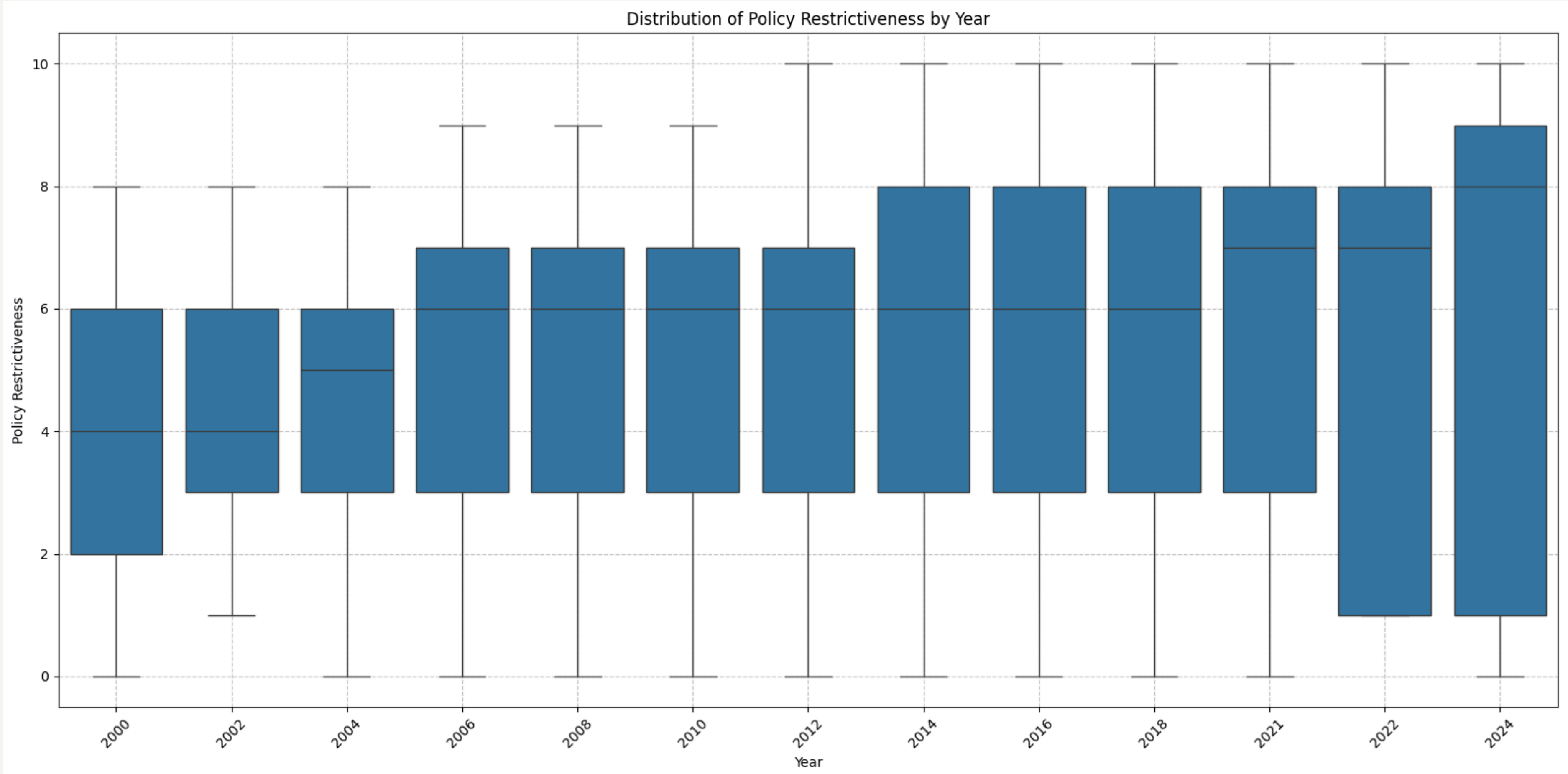
Ballotpedia

State partisan control: governorship, state House, and state Senate

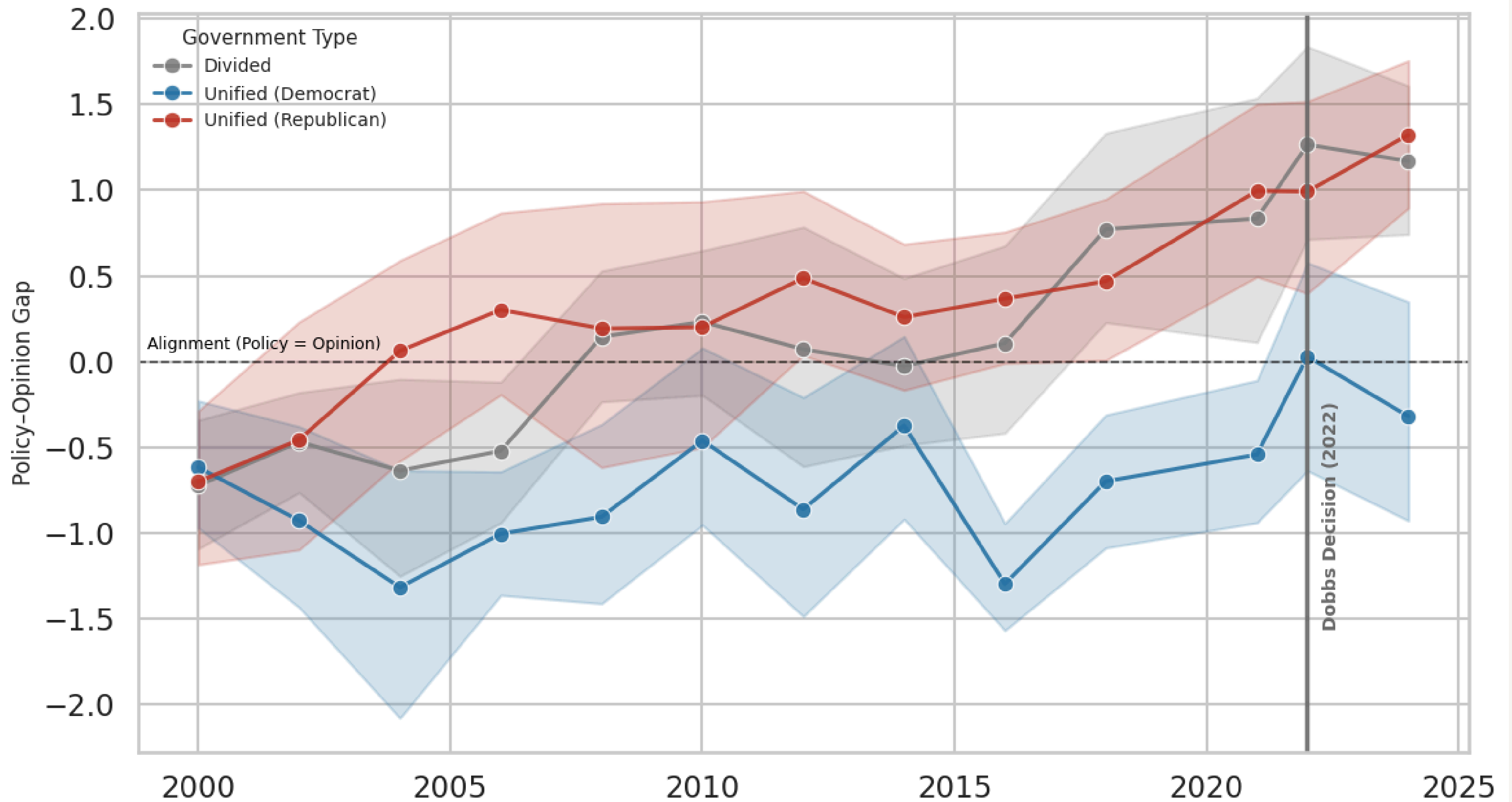
Weighted Mean Abortion Restrictiveness in Public Opinion, 2000–2024



Data comes from the General Social Survey Waves (2000-2024) and is weighted by WTSSPS. Higher values indicate less support for legality of abortion - Lower values indicate more support for legality of abortion.

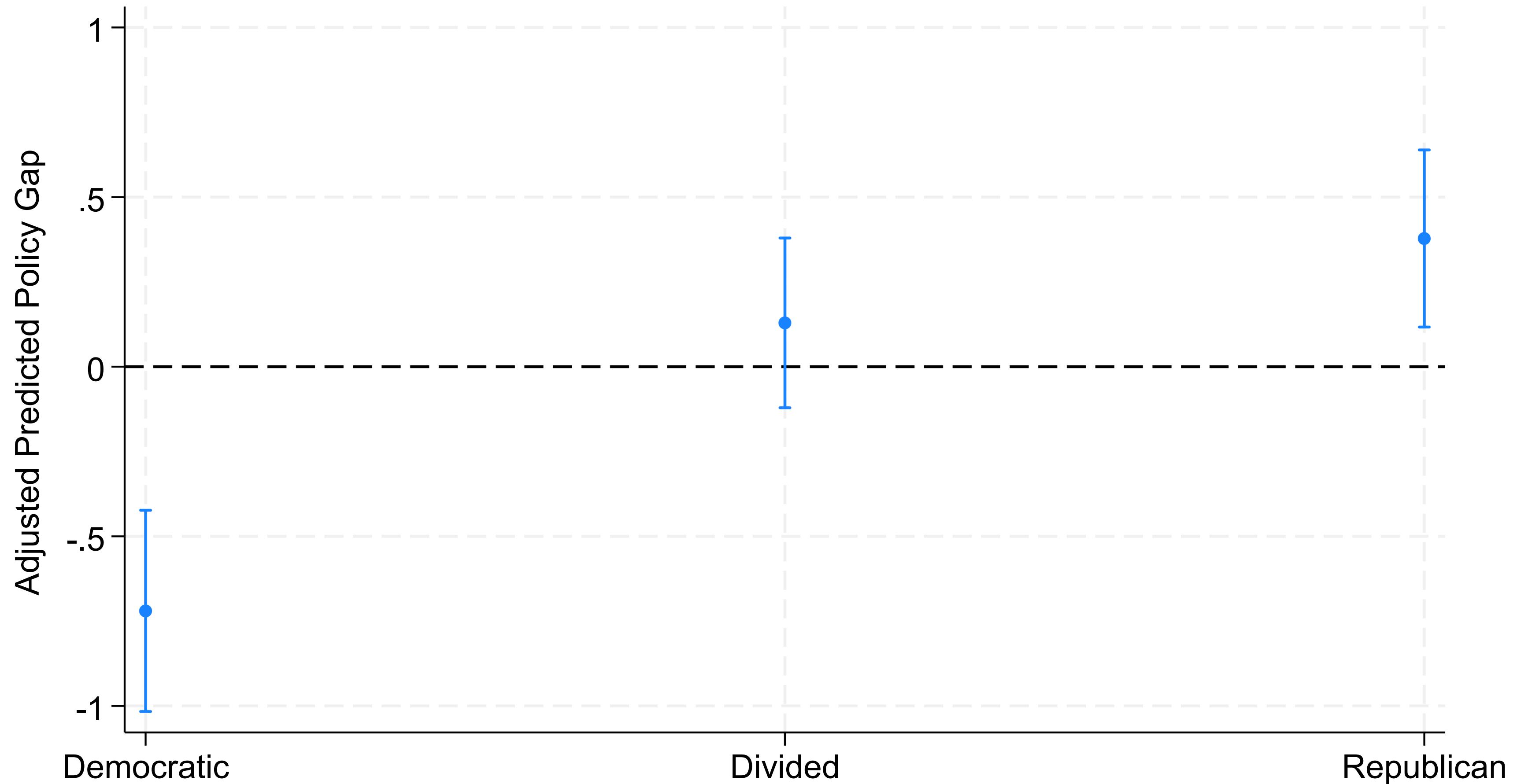


Policy-Opinion Gap Over Time by Government Type (2000-2024)

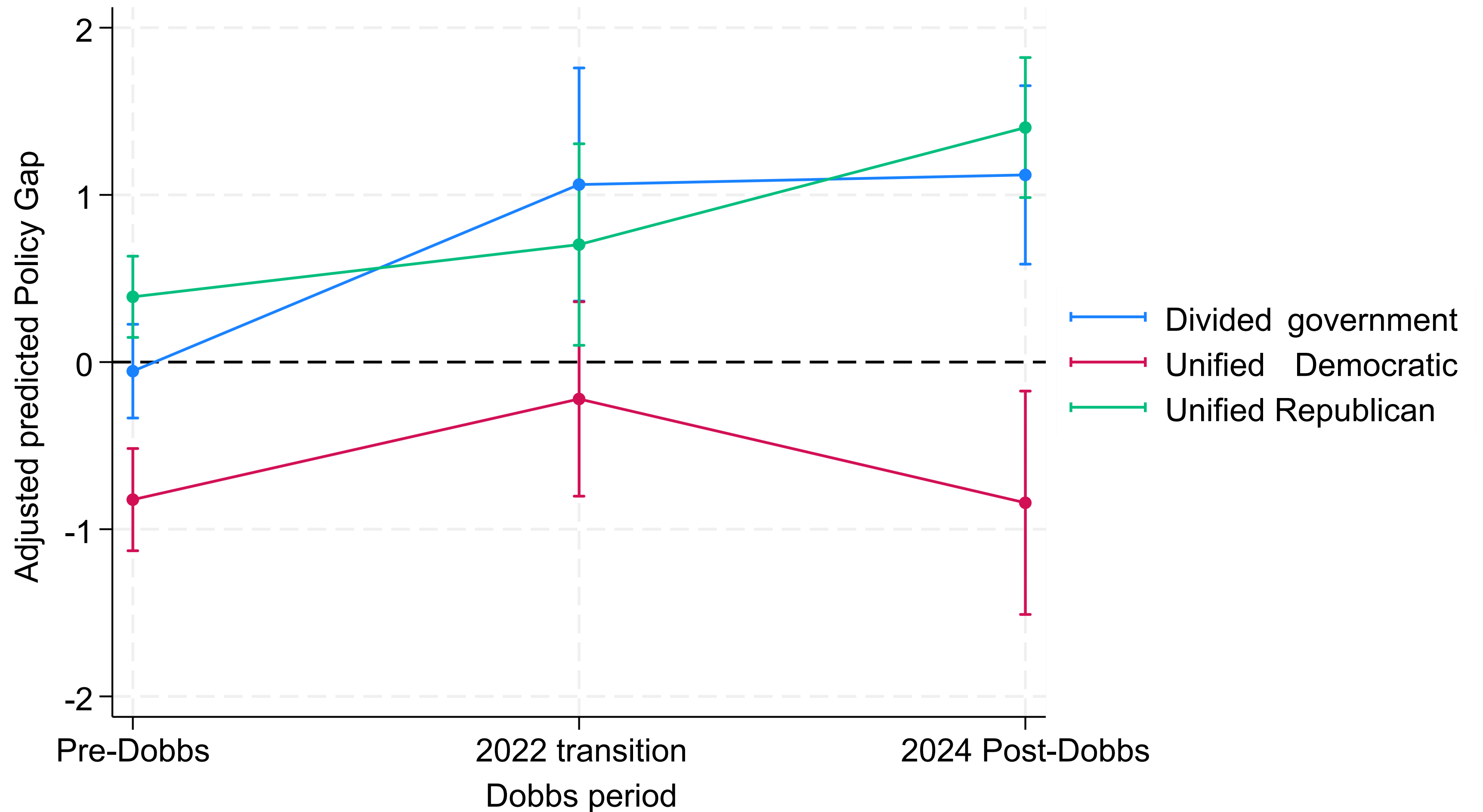


Note: Positive values indicate policy is more restrictive than public opinion; negative values indicate less restrictive policy; 0 represents alignment.

Adjusted Policy Gap by State Government Control



Adjusted Policy Gap by Government Control and Dobbs Period



Takeaways

1

Partisan control is associated with the direction of policy–opinion alignment.

2

Unified Democratic governments are associated with a lower Policy Gap compared with divided government, indicating movement in a more permissive direction.

3

The Policy Gap has shifted in a more restrictive direction over time, and divided government does not consistently produce policy–opinion alignment.

Fully Adjusted OLS Model Predicting Policy Gap

Predictor	b (SE)
Unified Republican	0.249 (0.168)
Unified Democratic	-0.849*** (0.164)
Year	0.079*** (0.018)
Political Views	-0.277** (0.122)
Religious Attendance	-0.342*** (0.067)
Bachelor’s degree or higher (%)	0.013 (0.022)
Median age	−0.134* (0.072)
Black (%)	0.005 (0.018)
Hispanic (%)	−0.006 (0.013)
White (%)	0.016* (0.009)
Female (%)	0.267 (0.232)
Married (%)	−0.005 (0.010)

N = 445
Divided government is the reference category. Standard errors clustered by state.
* p < .10, ** p < .05, *** p < .01